

INDUSTRY NEWS



Cisco sued over GPL violations

The Free Software Foundation (FSF) has filed a copyright infringement lawsuit against Cisco. The FSF's complaint alleges that in the course of distributing various Linksys products, Cisco has violated the licences of many programs on which the FSF holds copyright, including GCC, binutils, and the GNU C Library. In doing so, Cisco has denied its users their right to share and modify the software.

The programs are either licensed under the GPL or LGPL. Both these licences encourage everyone, including companies like Cisco, to modify the software as they see fit and then share it with others, under certain conditions. One of those conditions says that anyone who redistributes the software must also provide their recipients with the source code to that program.

The FSF has documented many instances where Cisco has distributed licensed software but failed to provide its customers with the corresponding source code.

"We began working with Cisco in 2003 to help them establish a process for complying with our

software licences, and the initial changes were very promising," explained Brett Smith, licensing compliance engineer at the FSF. "Unfortunately, they never put in the effort that was necessary to finish the process, and now five years later we have still not seen a plan for compliance. As a result, we believe that legal action is the best way to restore the rights we grant to all users of our software."

The complaint was filed on December 11, 2008 in the US District Court for the Southern District of New York by the Software Freedom Law Centre, which is providing representation to the FSF in this case. A copy of the complaint is available at www.fsf.org/licensing/complaint-2008-12-11.pdf

Nokia acquires Symbian

Nokia has completed the acquisition of Symbian Ltd. Symbian is the software company that develops and licenses the Symbian OS, an operating system targeted for mobile devices. User interfaces designed for the Symbian OS include S60 from Nokia, MOAP (S) for the 3G network and UIQ, designed by UIQ Technology, a joint venture between Motorola and Sony Ericsson. Nokia, now, owns more than 99.9 per cent of Symbian shares. It is planned that all Symbian employees will become Nokia employees on February 1, 2009.

In June 2008, Nokia announced a plan to acquire the 52 per cent of Symbian it doesn't already own and set up the Symbian Foundation, making the platform open source in the process. Nokia said it would buy out the remaining Symbian shares from Sony Ericsson, Panasonic, Siemens and Samsung for € 264 million.

Lee Williams, nominated executive director, Symbian Foundation, said, "When the Foundation begins operations, which is expected during the first half of 2009, it will have a uniquely strong ecosystem of developers, manufacturers and network operators, all committed to building an open platform to set free the future of mobiles."

As previously announced, the Symbian Foundation will work to make the platform available in open source by June 2010.

Theodore Ts'o is the new CTO at the Linux Foundation

The Linux Foundation has appointed Linux kernel developer Theodore Ts'o as its chief technology officer. Ts'o will be replacing Markus Rex, who recently returned to Novell to work as the acting general manager and senior vice president of its OPS business unit.

In his new role, Ts'o will lead all technical initiatives for the Linux Foundation, including oversight of the Linux Standard Base (LSB) and other work groups such as Open Printing. He will also be the primary technical interface to LF members and the LF's technical advisory board, which represents the kernel community.

"Ted is an invaluable member of the Linux Foundation team, and we are happy he is available to assume the role of CTO where his contributions will be critical to the advancement of Linux," said Jim Zemlin, executive director, the Linux Foundation. "We are also very grateful to Markus Rex for his assignment at the Foundation and thank him and Novell for their commitments to Linux and the LSB."

Ts'o has been a Linux Foundation fellow since December 2007. Since 2001, Ts'o has worked as a senior technical staff member at IBM, where he most recently led a worldwide team to create an enterprise-level real-time Linux solution. He will return to IBM after this two-year fellowship at The Linux Foundation.

Ts'o is known as the first North American kernel developer. Other current and past LF fellows include Steve Hemminger, Andrew Morton, Linus Torvalds and Andrew Tridgell.

